

Teaching Statement

Adriane Fresh

Teaching Philosophy

Most undergraduate students arrive in a political science class with some interest in *politics*, but limited understanding of *political science*. With this in mind, I ground my teaching in the scientific method, arranging substantive content on this foundation. Asking the right question, formulating an answer, and properly interpreting evidence in support of that answer are the core skills I believe will allow my students to make sense of the world—especially, but not just the political world—and contribute to it regardless of their post-college careers.

I ask students to start first with developing their *understanding* of discoveries in the field. To accomplish this, students build their critical reading skills—a skill we often assume students have, but don't work to cultivate. In a semester-long college class on research methods for which I was lead instructor at San Quentin State Prison, I dedicated an entire class to a careful breakdown of one academic article. Students, unaccustomed to scholarly texts, generated their own goals for the reading, and then read together in small groups, working through a set of leading questions that pointed them to key components—the abstract, the research question, the findings. I approach political science texts similarly for my Duke students through the use of short reading (comprehension) worksheets that accompany every text that I assign. This helps students who may have experience with scholarly work, but nevertheless struggle to read for key ideas and synthesize information beyond memorizable facts.

Equipped with understanding, I work with students to develop their *analytical and evaluative* skills. To build knowledge of politics as science in my classes, I draw from history, current events and the diversity of personal interests that my students bring to class. For instance, in my undergraduate course on institutions at Duke, I pair readings on theoretical topics about institutions (e.g., what defines an institution; how do institutions originate) with readings about specific institutional examples (e.g., prison gangs, capitalism). Students then have the opportunity to apply their new theoretical knowledge to concrete examples, considering how these theories illuminate, and also probing what is still left unexplained. In this way, I allow students extensive opportunities to build rich factual knowledge; knowledge that both deepens their scientific understanding, and makes the study of politics truly come alive.

I also consider it essential for students to *create* answers of their own; that is, to engage in discovery themselves, even in courses that aren't explicitly about conducting research. Given the increasing importance of quantitative evidence in the political science field and what we might call statistical or data “literacy” in the job market, one of the biggest challenges I've encountered to students creating answers of their own is their comfort with quantitative concepts. I've worked to overcome this challenge by developing lab-style activities that generate intuitive understanding, and slowly build concrete statistical programming skills to empower students. Through this process of creation, I aim to introduce my students to the rich complexity of the political world, and the idea that definitive answers are hard to come by but very worthwhile to pursue.

Teaching Experience

I have extensive teaching experience in a diverse set of environments at Duke and beyond. In addition to improving my teaching through practice, I learned about successful evidence-based teaching strategies through a Stanford graduate-level course on teaching pedagogy, and worked one-on-one with graduate students as a university-wide teaching consultant through Stanford's

Vice Provost for Teaching and Learning. As a graduate student, I also re-designed and facilitated Stanford political science department’s annual TA training for two consecutive years.

At Duke, I teach undergraduates in the course *Political, Social and Economic Institutions*, which I informally title “Understanding Institutions to Change the World.” This is a seminar course which considers three Big Ideas (in Hansen’s terminology):¹ institutions fundamentally structure human behavior, institutions are everywhere, and institutions are hard to change. To explore those big ideas—and achieve a concrete set of course learning goals—students choose a problem that exists in the world that matters to them (e.g., takeaway food waste, refugee resettlement). I then backwards-designed a series of linked assignments in which students describe an institution that intersects with their problem, and propose a solution in the form of institutional change. Via course readings, students explore both conceptual and theoretical literature on institutions, and they apply those concepts and theories to specific examples of institutions. Colloquial narratives of social change often pay lip service to institutional change—but students leaving my class have a deep understanding of what that means, and a toolkit to begin that process themselves.

At Duke, I also teach the graduate Causal Inference and Scope and Methods courses targeted at first-year first-term PhD students. Although these courses are designed for doctoral students with different learning goals than most undergraduates, these courses are adapted from a Research Design course that I taught in Spring 2017 while a graduate student at Stanford, the first time the course was taught by a graduate student. I designed my own syllabus that introduced students to the designs other scholars have used to answer their research questions, approaches of drawing inferences from different types of evidence, and led students through short authentic assignments that built to their final project proposal. The final research design submitted by one of my students won the Hoefer Prize for Writing in the Major for the year across all of the social sciences.

At San Quentin State Prison in CA and Turney Industrial Complex in TN, I’ve served as an instructor for accredited college courses in Latin American history, generalized research methods, and macroeconomics where I have designed and implemented my own syllabi. These courses have allowed me to test the effectiveness of my teaching skills with inmate student populations far more diverse in age, race, life experience and educational preparation than at a typical university. In particular, I’ve it is crucial to assess students’ prior knowledge early in the term to build upon students’ existing frameworks of knowledge rather than those that I assume they have.²

Across all of my teaching, I work hard to create a space in which high value is placed on students’ individual cultural knowledge, but where existing beliefs and frameworks can nevertheless be challenged. Rather than being at odds, as many contemporary media narratives portray, in my experience, supporting diversity, equity and inclusion in the classroom has enhanced the intellectual experience of my students.

Teaching Awards & Evaluations

I have received outstanding evaluations in my courses and been recognized for my teaching with two separate awards as a top 5% instructor in Duke’s Trinity College in Fall 2020 and Spring 2021, and the 2014 Stanford Centennial Teaching Assistant award, granted to only a handful of outstanding teaching assistants from across the university each year.

My course evaluations, listed below, indicate my efforts to develop student thinking utilizing clear explanations and detailed but targeted feedback.

¹E. Hansen. *Idea Based Learning: A Course Design Process to Promote Conceptual Understanding*. 2011.

²S.A. Ambrose et. al. *How Learning Works: 7 Research-Based Principles for Smart Teaching*. 2010.

Undergraduate Course Evaluation Scores

	Clear Learning Objectives	Welcoming & Inclusive	Helped Apply Knowledge	Helped Effective Writing
Political, Social, Economic Institutions (F2019)	4.21	4.71	4.50	4.21
Political, Social, Economic Institutions (F2020)	4.89	5.00	5.00	4.89
Political, Social, Economic Institutions (S2021)	5.00	5.00	5.00	4.86

All Duke courses for which the maximum possible score is 5.0. Selected components are displayed. Fall 2021 courses switched to a new comment-focused evaluation form (see selected comments below). Full evaluations happily available upon request. My Duke graduate courses did not receive an official Duke course evaluation.

Comments that students have provided me on my teaching emphasize the importance that I place on student learning, and the diverse strategies that I use to achieve learning goals.

- “The class was very stimulating because it made me start thinking about things I experience every day in a brand new way.” (Duke, PS&E Institutions, Fall 2021)
- “Very interesting and applicable class even if you have no background in political science. Expect to thoroughly read several readings a week. Professor Fresh does a great job breaking down the content and making it relevant to the institutions in our lives.” (Duke, PS&E Institutions, Fall 2021)
- “The differences in article ‘topics’ kept the conversations interesting while still building on concepts from previous discussions.” (Duke, PS&E Institutions, Fall 2021)
- “I liked how we would get into little groups and then present what we think then because it’s less pressure and also you’re able to absorb many other’s opinion all at the same time.” (Duke, PS&E Institutions, Fall 2021)
- “Professor Fresh is an incredibly knowledgeable, helpful and caring teacher and she makes sure that everything is well structured and clear.” (Duke, PS&E Institutions, Spring 2021)
- “Professor Fresh expects a lot from you but she provides the resources you need to do well. Her comments on essays are fantastic and very constructive.” (Duke, PS&E Institutions, Fall 2020)
- “I greatly appreciate Adriane’s patience in explaining difficult concepts. She was always willing to go over challenging ideas multiple times and to provide different ways to understand them.” (Stanford, Research Design, Fall 2016)
- “... Section was also very well planned out. The worksheets Adriane made were immensely helpful... I felt like I learned more in one 50 minute section than the 2 hour lectures.” (Stanford, Intro to Comparative Politics, Spring 2014)
- “The material and lectures were the best I’ve ever encountered in [the Prison University Project at San Quentin]. This was the first time I actually looked forward to coming to a college class.” (San Quentin, Race, Class and Nation in Latin America, Spring 2014)
- “... She gauged which information [from] lecture was the most difficult for us to grasp and focused section around this. We did this through alternate explanations, theories, debates and group collaborations—all of which were helpful.” (Stanford, Intro to International Relations, Fall 2012)